# A License to Drive, Not a Lifetime Pass: Why Elderly Drivers Should Be Retested

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In 2011, Ray, a man of 74 years who loved his church, fishing, and his family (in that order), was killed in a car accident that was entirely preventable. His loved ones had long known that something was amiss with Ray. His eyesight was not what it used to be, nor was his memory, and combined with personality and behavior changes, this all suggested that he was not fit to be behind the wheel. But in spring of 2011, he did get behind the wheel, drove for several miles going the wrong direction on the interstate, and caused a head-on collision. Both Ray and the other driver lost their lives, and two others were injured. If his loved ones had intervened or had the Indiana BMV required a driver of his age to retake a vision test every renewal, or required he renew his license in person, he likely would not have been driving, and two lives might have been spared that day.

This unfortunately is not the only story of this occurring. According to Lombardi et al. (2017), drivers aged 70-74 were found to be approximately 20% more likely to be in fatal car accidents than drivers aged 20-24, and that risk was found to nearly double by age 85. For their safety and ours, elderly individuals should be required to undergo periodic retesting for their driver's licenses, as age-related visual and cognitive decline can significantly impact driving ability.

A person's mental ability, including memory, orientation to surroundings, reaction time, and so on, are all important aspects of one's ability to drive safely – and each of these can decline as we age. A study was done in Spain by the National University of Distance Education, which focused on changes in reaction times in older adults with and without mild cognitive impairment, as compared to younger adults (Ballesteros S. et al., 2013). This series of tests found that "older adults were significantly slower in simple and choice reaction-time tasks,"

(Ballesteros S. et al., 2013, pg. 23.) This decline in reaction time can make the difference in a driver avoiding an accident or potentially losing their life.

Memory loss is another common symptom of aging – and while the usual age-related memory loss does not inherently require major life changes, the decline from occasionally misplacing your keys to forgetting the meaning of road signs and traffic signals can begin gradually and get worse as time goes on (Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research 2024). These changes can often be overlooked or downplayed, leading to potentially dangerous situations. Requiring drivers to renew their license in person or retake a written test may help to determine if drivers are mentally capable of being in command of a vehicle.

Another typical issue with aging that can advance slowly and go unnoticed is changes in vision. According to the American Optometric Association (AOA, n.d.-a), age-related vision problems can begin as early as 40. Common age-related vision problems include increased glare from headlights, needing more light to see well, and changes in color perception – all of which can affect driving skills and the ability to avoid an accident. The AOA themselves call a driver's license vision test to be an "insufficient screening", and say such tests are unreliable to determine if someone has a vision or eye problem (AOA, n.d.-a).

In another article, the AOA (n.d.-b) indicates that individuals over the age of 60 are also at increased risk for more severe vision conditions such as cataracts, glaucoma, and macular degeneration. Some eye conditions such as glaucoma can have subtle or no symptoms until there is significant vision loss. Mandated vision tests at every driver's license renewal would ensure that drivers maintain the visual acuity necessary to respond to traffic signs, changing road conditions, and unexpected hazards – as well as potentially allow for early treatment of these

conditions. Since driving is a task that heavily relies on visual input, it is not unreasonable to require all drivers to prove their eyes are still up to the task at every renewal.

Some places have already made policy changes regarding elderly drivers and have seen a decrease in accidents as a result. In 2009, Japan began requiring drivers over the age of 75 to take a cognitive test to renew their license, or after committing certain traffic violations such as ignoring traffic lights. The test evaluates a driver's memory recall and temporal orientation. As of 2017, any driver who is deemed by the test to be at risk must then be evaluated by a doctor to assess for dementia in order to continue driving (National Police Agency, n.d.). A study by Inada H. et al. (2023) found that following the policy change in Japan requiring these tests, there was a noticeable decrease in vehicle collisions in drivers over the age of 75, indicating that the policy change was effective.

Some, such as Eli Lehrer (2008), argue that requiring elderly drivers to retest is discriminatory and unfairly targets a group based on age. They claim that age alone should not determine driving ability and that plenty of older adults are perfectly capable of driving safely. While this concern is valid - no one wants to feel stereotyped or judged simply for getting older - the intent of retesting is not to punish elderly individuals, but to protect everyone on the road, including them. In fact, retesting is a way to offer support by identifying issues that could put elderly drivers in danger or find conditions that may grow worse if left untreated. Rather than being discriminatory, the ideal policy would require all drivers regardless of age to renew in person, retake a full vision test each time, and occasionally retake the written or road tests – either at certain intervals or only after infractions occur. This would ensure that changes to a person's driving privileges are based on health and performance - not just age - and could include options like conditional licenses or driver refresher courses. The goal is not to remove

driving privileges arbitrarily, but to ensure that those who hold a license are still equipped to use it safely.

Another argument often used is that older drivers are supposedly the safest age range. Some statistics, such as ones published by the Illinois Department of Transportation (IDOT, 2021), find elderly drivers to be involved in the least number of accidents. They list the total number of crashes per 1000 licensed drivers to be 24.59 for ages 75 or older, compared to 42.62 accidents per 1000 drivers aged 50-54, and as high as 87.02 per 1000 for drivers aged 18 (IDOT, 2021 pg. 27). But we must look at the details to notice a change in the pattern.

Many of these statistics, such as the one above, look at accidents per licensed driver, ignoring the fact that many older drivers who legally hold a driver's license choose not to drive due to knowledge of their own abilities (Braitman K.A. & McCartt A.T., 2008). As found by Papa et al. (2014) “When analysis was restricted to only current drivers, we found a significantly higher percentage of vehicle crash involvement among older compared to younger drivers,” (pg. 3). While the majority of elderly drivers may be safer than their younger counterparts, this is in part because the safest drivers know when it might time to hang up their keys or to self-impose restrictions such as only driving during daylight hours or not on bustling highways. An ideal policy change would simply lead to putting these sorts of necessary restrictions on drivers who may be unaware of how dangerous their driving truly is, or those who may be too stubborn to admit when they are no longer up to the task.

As people age, physical and mental changes are inevitable. Vision tends to decline, reaction times slow, and cognitive processing can become less sharp - all of which directly impact a person’s ability to operate a vehicle safely. While many older adults are capable drivers, some may no longer recognize their own limitations, or may be reluctant to stop driving due to a

loss of independence. Unfortunately, this can lead to dangerous situations not only for themselves, but for everyone else on the road. Regular retesting offers a fair and proactive way to ensure that age-related decline is identified before it leads to tragedy.

Now that the risks are clear, the question becomes: what can we do about it? The next step is to advocate for safer driving practices for older adults. This could mean supporting legislation that requires periodic vision and driving skills testing for drivers regardless of age, spreading awareness about the real risks of driving once impaired by age-related decline, providing alternative transport for those unable to drive on their own, or simply having honest conversations with aging loved ones when concerns arise. Ensuring road safety is not just about sympathy for older drivers – it is about taking action to protect lives. Because had someone taken action all those years ago, Ray might still be alive.

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